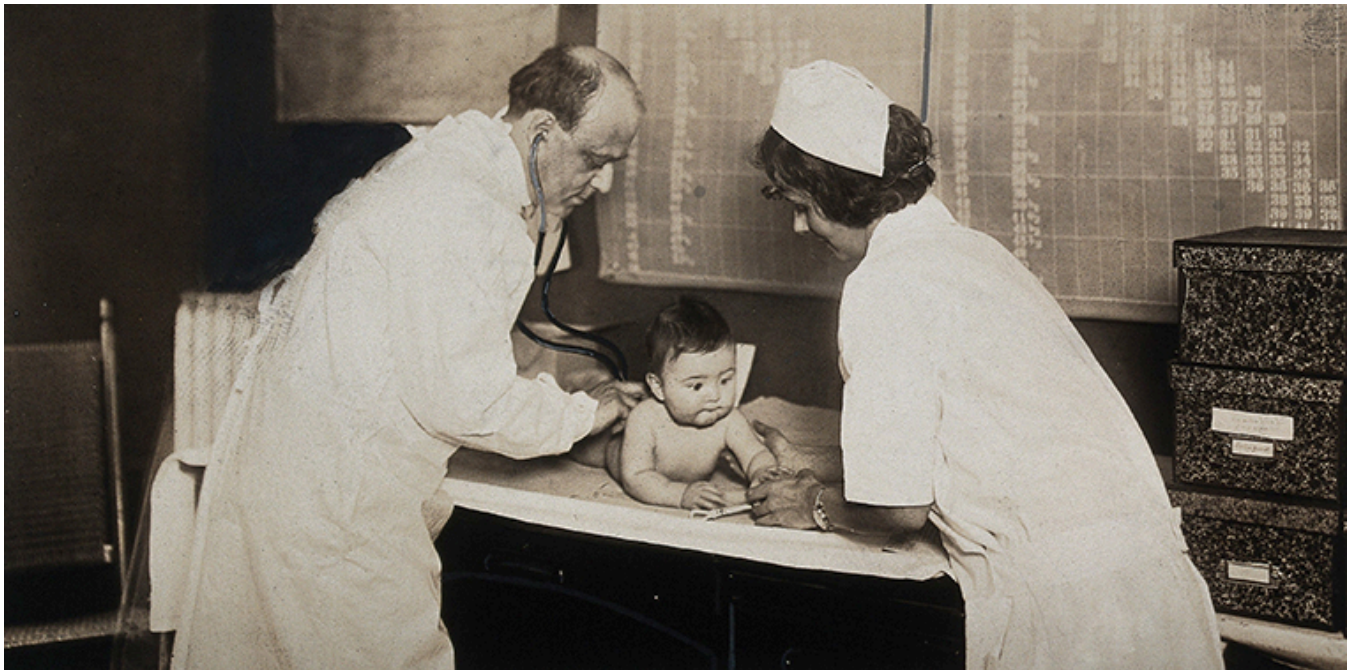


Reading from Global Health

Global Health Then and Now

The world has become healthier over the past few centuries, but new challenges are on the horizon.

Last Updated: June 13, 2025



A baby is examined by a nurse and a doctor with a stethoscope at a state baby clinic in Pennsylvania, circa 1925. Maternal and infant deaths have declined extraordinarily since then.

Source: Wellcome Collection

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Health has played a critical role in shaping the world's economies and societies throughout human history. As civilizations have advanced and globalized, new challenges in human disease, nutrition, sanitation, and public health financing have emerged. So, too, have advances and innovations that have helped human beings live longer and healthier lives than ever before.

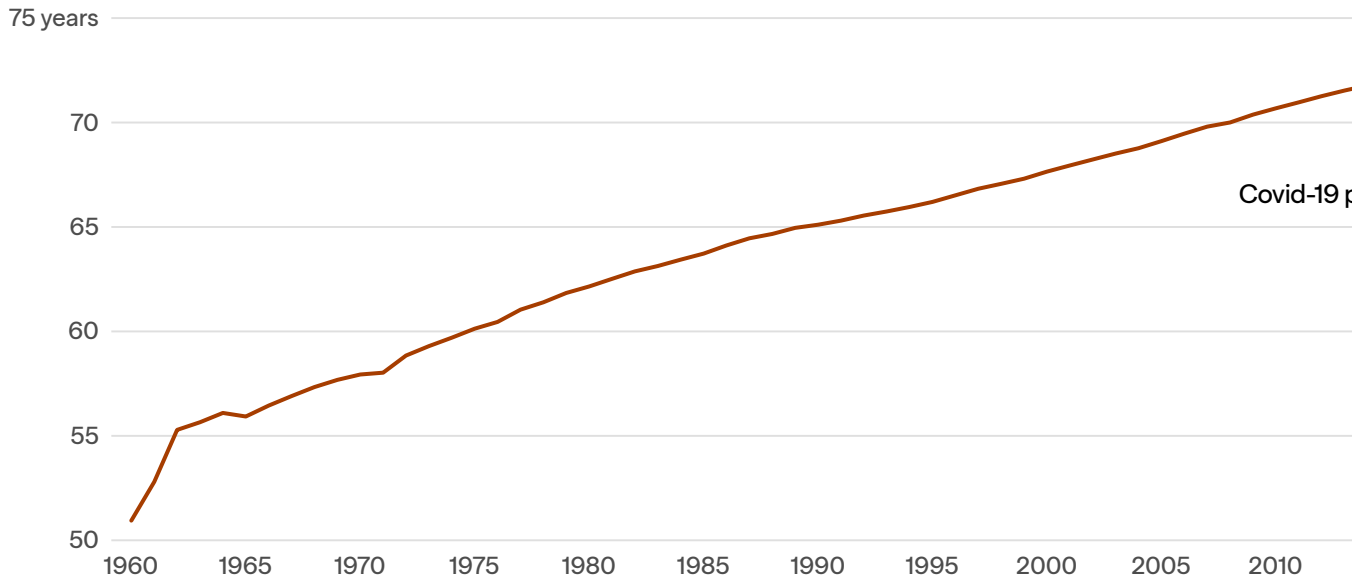
As communities look forward to the future and the new challenges that could emerge, they should take stock of just how far the world's health-care systems have come in two centuries.

In 1800, for example, the estimated [global life expectancy](#)  was just twenty-nine years. Today, global life expectancy is around seventy-three years. That means that in just two centuries, the average length of people's lives has more than doubled thanks to great strides in areas such as [medical research, sanitation, and vaccines](#). 

Those gains reflect the world's increased commitment to improving global health. Over the past century, new organizations and funding to advance human wellness have steadily grown. Hundreds of different governmental and nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), international organizations, governments, funds, and initiatives now work on health issues, including the Gates Foundation, Doctors Without Borders, and the [World Health Organization](#). Gavi, a vaccines-focused public-private partnership, has helped vaccinate over one billion children since it was founded in 2000.

Lifespans Have Increased Over the Past Sixty Years

Global life expectancy at year of birth



Source: [World Bank](#) • [Get the data](#)

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Thanks in part to many of those organizations, certain infectious diseases no longer pose major threats.

For thousands of years, smallpox ravaged parts of the globe, killing about one-third of those who caught it. But better science led to a new vaccine, which, combined with funding and political will, resulted in its official eradication of the disease in 1980. A disease that killed an estimated three hundred million in the twentieth century alone now no longer endangers societies.

Polio has almost been eradicated too. Just over three decades ago, the disease was common in 125 countries. Today, it's geographically prevalent in—or endemic to—just two: Afghanistan and Pakistan. Polio persists in those settings largely because delivering vaccines there is difficult, either for geographic reasons—many people live in rural areas or move around frequently—or for political reasons, such as local mistrust of Western NGOs.

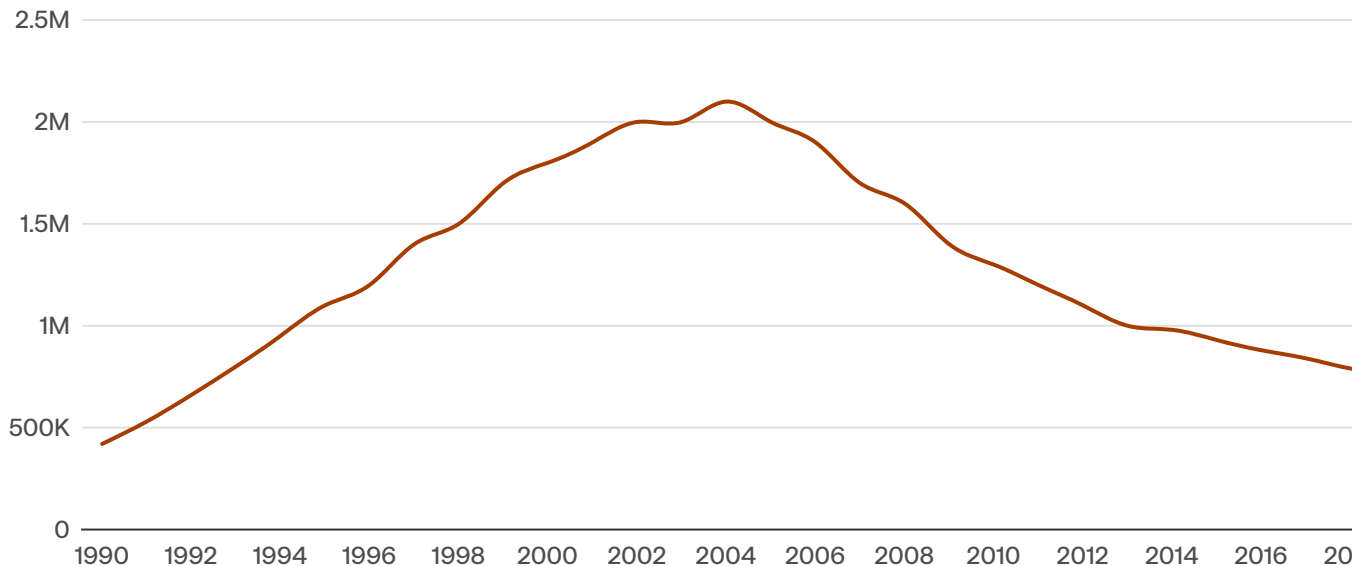
Despite a century of progress, however, infectious diseases remain a threat. And global

health gains haven't been uniform.

Medical experts have made progress worldwide in preventing and treating HIV/AIDS. In 2023, global deaths from the virus had decreased by 69 percent since its peak in 2004. New HIV infections have also fallen: by the end of 2023, about thirty million people with HIV were accessing antiretroviral therapy—up significantly from just eight million in 2010. But nearly forty million people still live with HIV/AIDS, the majority of them in Africa, despite a large, coordinated effort to counter the epidemic.

The Global AIDS Epidemic Peaked in 2004

Estimated number of deaths attributed to HIV-related illnesses worldwide

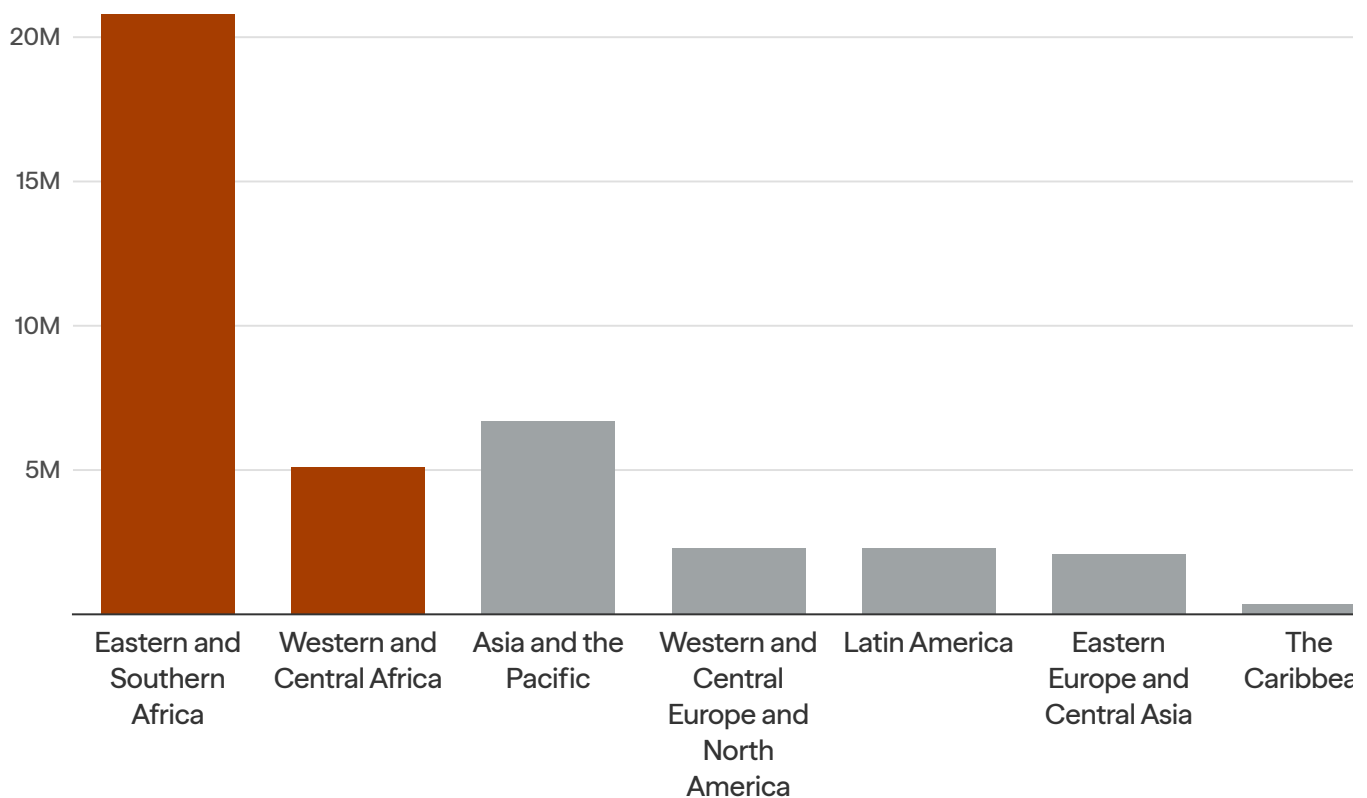


Source: [World Health Organization](#). • [Get the data](#)

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The Majority of People Living with HIV Live in Africa

Estimated population living with HIV by region as of 2023



Source: [UNAIDS](#) • [Get the data](#)

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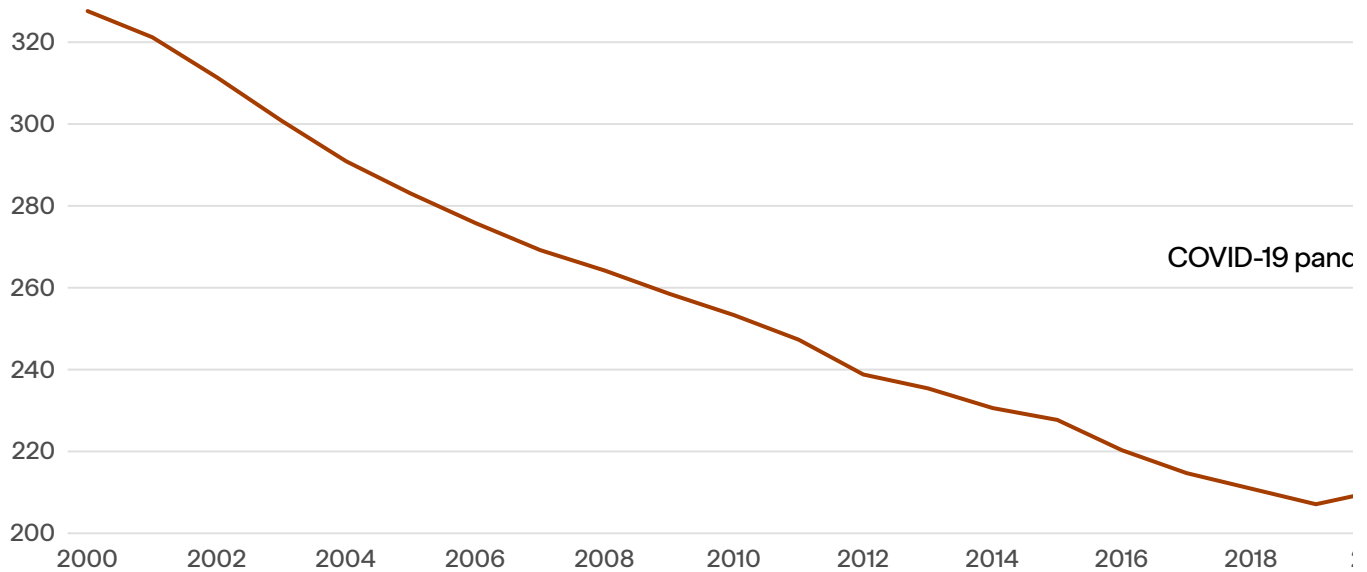
Nor are those gains permanent.

Maternal and infant deaths have declined extraordinarily since 2000, when the United Nations announced a set of priorities, the Millennium Development Goals, that included children's and mothers' health. Since then, governments, NGOs, and private partners have invested in more programs—such as sex education, nutrition, and pre- and postnatal care—that help mothers and babies stay healthy. More families also have access to better clinics and trained health professionals.

Despite the decline in global maternal mortality rates in the twenty-first century, since 2016, rates in the Americas and Europe have either increased or stagnated.

Global Maternal Mortality Rate Has Declined Significantly

Estimated global number of maternal pregnancy related deaths per 100,000 live births



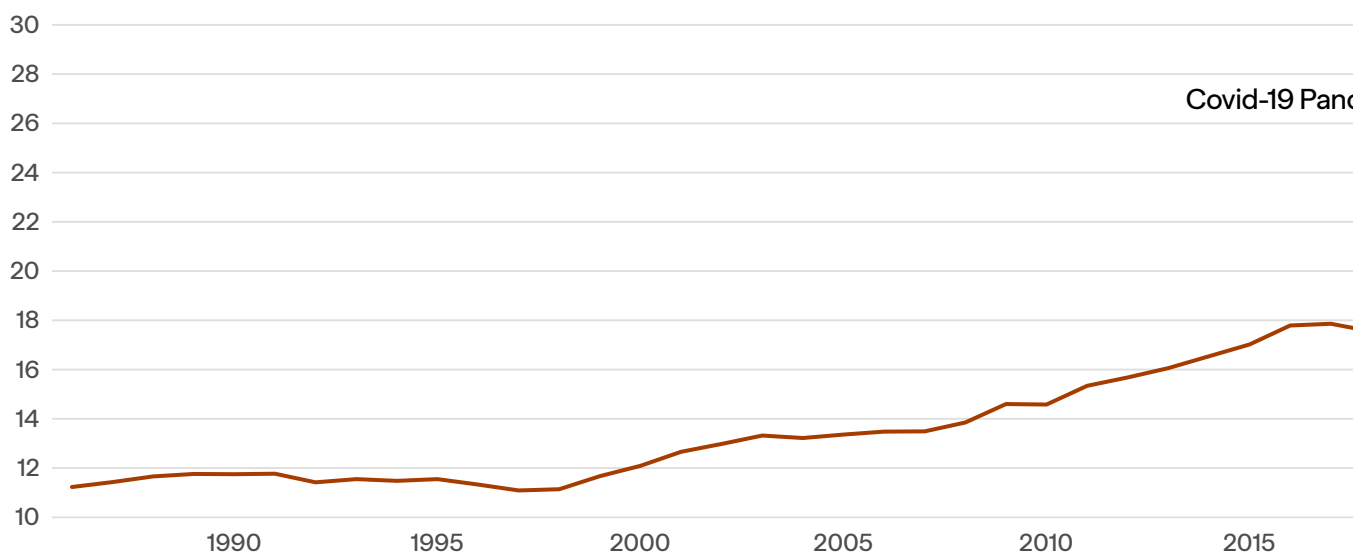
Source: [World Health Organization](#) • [Get the data](#)

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Maternal mortality has risen and seen a recent spike in the United States—the only high-income country where that increase is occurring. Those climbing numbers are particularly concerning in how they relate to U.S. racial disparities: in 2023, the country's Black maternal mortality rate was nearly 3.5 times higher than its white maternal mortality rate.

Maternal Mortality Rates Rise in the United States

Estimated number of maternal pregnancy related deaths per 100,000 live births

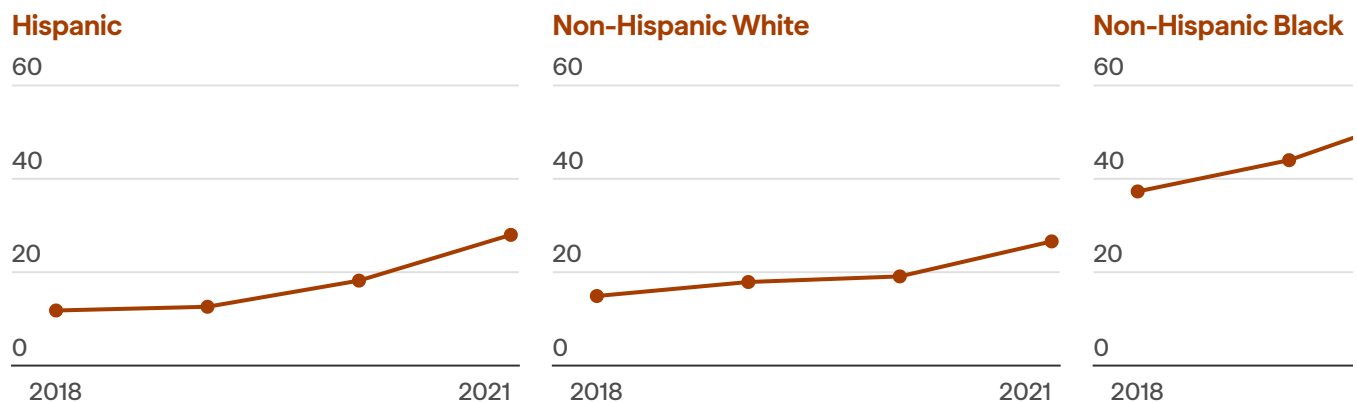


Source: [World Health Organization](#). • [Get the data](#)

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Black Mothers More Likely to Die in United States

Number of pregnancy-related deaths per 100,000 live births by race



Source: [Centers for Disease Control and Prevention](#). • [Get the data](#)

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While a century of progress can't be discounted, the world continues to face health challenges.

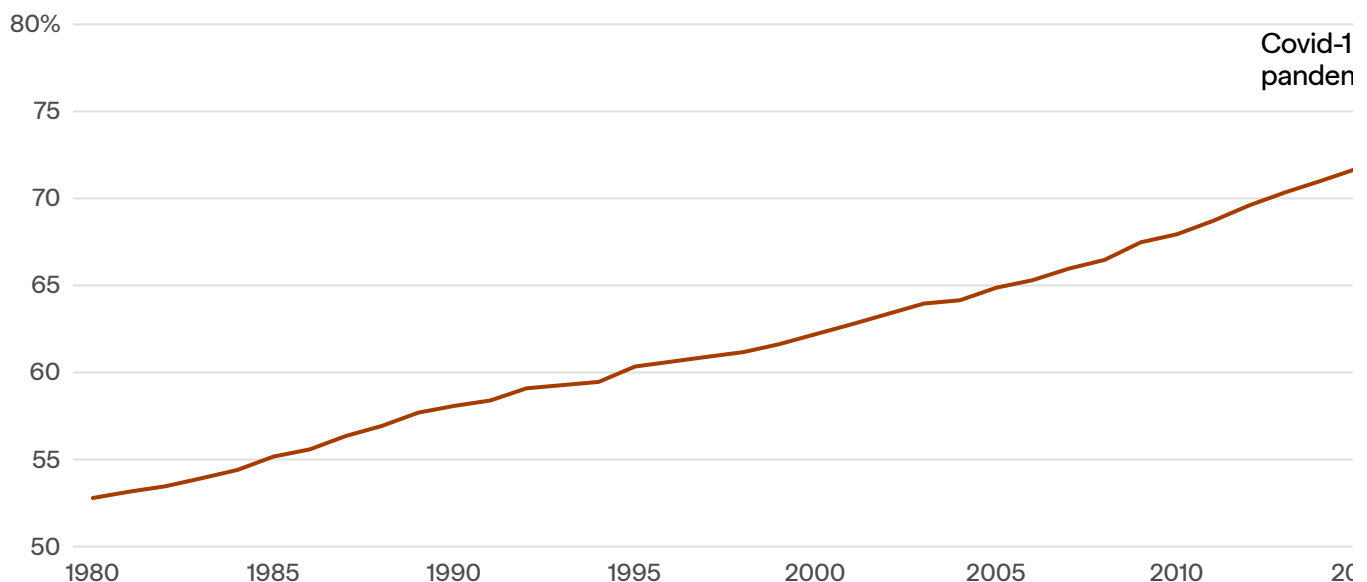
Meanwhile, the world is combating the rise of other health threats called noncommunicable diseases (NCDs). NCDs do not spread from person to person. Heart disease, for example, is now the biggest killer in the United States—it causes one in every five deaths. That statistic mirrors a global trend. In 2000, just four of

the top ten causes of death worldwide were NCDs; by 2019, that number had grown to seven out of ten. Worldwide, over seventy percent of all deaths now result from NCDs—the majority from cardiovascular diseases.

In the United States, those illnesses disproportionately affect people of color. For instance, Black and Hispanic/Latino Americans face higher rates than white Americans of high blood pressure, obesity, and diabetes. NCDs can also be more deadly for people of color. Black, American Indian, and Native Hawaiian and Pacific Islander populations are roughly twice [as likely](#) to die of diabetes than white Americans, for example.

More People Dying From Noncommunicable Diseases

Global percentage of deaths from non-communicable diseases by year



Source: [Institute for Health Metrics and Evaluation](#). • [Get the data](#)

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The questions surrounding how best to treat NCDs and how to tackle other emerging health challenges emblemize a shift in the global health field: the idea that health is about more than just doctor visits and vaccinations. In fact, a range of issues—including poverty, gender equality, systemic racism, and climate change—affect a person's health and their vulnerability to NCDs. Advances in those related areas mean progress in global health too.